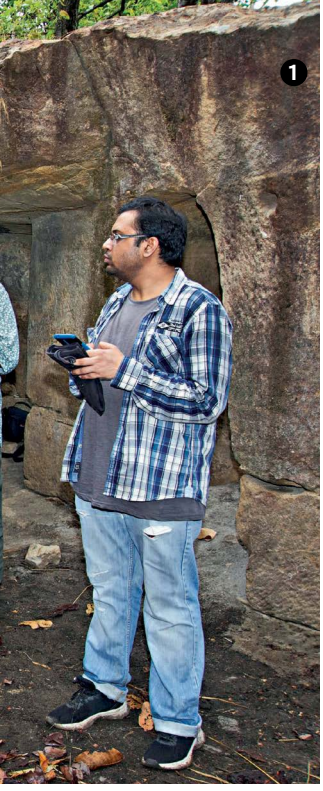
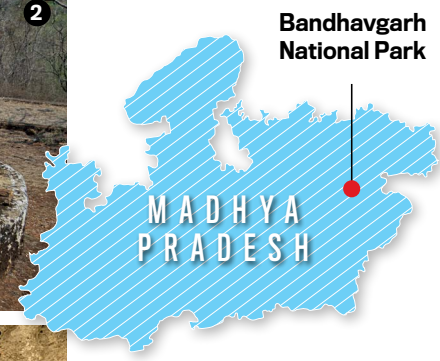


Photographs by SATYENDRA KUMAR TIWARI









ANCIENT TREASURES **1.** Prof. Nayanjot Lahiri with her team **2.** Assemblage at Ghughwa fossil park **3.** *Purna kumbha* motif, 2nd c. AD **4.** Horse rider, 2nd c. AD

ARCHAEOLOGY

HUMANS OF BANDHAVGARH

life of early forest dwellers, with their technology developing around the use of chert, agate and chalcedony.

Another significant information came through lab corroborations at the Birbal Sahni Institute of Palaeosciences in Lucknow: the sal trees endemic to Bandhavgarh have been around since at least the 6th century BC. This continuity in tree species would interest environmentalists, as forests typically change in their nature over large time-scales.

Additionally, findings of fossil wood microliths at the Ghughwa fossil park not far from Bandhavgarh demonstrate that prehistoric communities made tools not just from stone, but also materials like fossilised wood. Madhya Pradesh is rich in prehistoric sites and is home to the Bhimbetka rock shelters and Hathnora, where the skull fragment of the ancient Narmada woman was found. In other prehistoric sites such as Pilikaran, Neemtone and Mahadev, artefacts are found to be typically made of stone—be it chert, sandstone or quartzite. The discovery of tools made from fossilised tree trunks dating back to the Cretaceous period over 65 million years ago adds to the state's historical richness. Such tools have previously been found in Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu and Tripura.

"Forests had a much bigger footprint than settled spaces in the past. I decided to work on Bandhavgarh to understand the pattern of past cultural imprints in woodlands and to address the nuances and challenges of recovering the past there," says Prof. Nayanjot Lahiri of Ashoka University, who has led the field research team at the reserve since 2021. Over the past year, the team, comprising prehistorian Akash Srinivas and others, has worked with Binita Phartiyal from the Birbal Sahni Institute of Palaeosciences and Karthick Balasubramanian from the Agharkar Research Institute in Pune to study vegetation and climate changes. A sediment core from the Chakradhara Meadow in Bandhavgarh was dated at a US-based lab, revealing insights into the ancient landscape. This work has been published in the research journal *Current Science*.

Bandhavgarh is not just a wildlife destination but a magnet for history buffs. Its core area boasts numerous ancient monuments—Buddhist rock-cut caves from the 2nd century AD, and temples and the famous Shesh Shaiyya or reclining Vishnu from the Kalachuri period (8th-13th c. AD). The Baghels, who ruled later from Rewa, used Bandhavgarh as hunting grounds, in a way restoring history to the forests where it began long ago. ■

THE FINDINGS

- **The first archaeological deep dive into a reserve forest yields evidence of habitation from >5000 BC**
- **The sal trees endemic to Bandhavgarh have been around since at least the 6th century BC**
- **The prehistoric communities made tools from stone and also from fossilised wood**